comparison between Indian and Chinese cultural traits. It looks critically at Chinese narratives about its own history, and questions interpretations of that history which serve a contemporary political purpose. For example, this book shows that while China looked upon India as a ‘slave nation’ ruled by a foreign power during the British colonial period, it ignored the fact that China itself was ruled by alien, non-Han dynasties for nearly half of its recorded history. It examines China’s claim to Tibet having been a part of China ‘since ancient times’ and shows that there is no historical evidence for this claim. Similarly, China’s claim that through most of recorded history it was the dominant power in Asia, with other countries in subordinate positions, is, as this book reveals, an artfully constructed narrative with no basis in historical fact.

China would like to see India slotted into a subordinate role in an Asia dominated by itself. India will resist a hierarchical order in Asia and a world dominated by China. However, this resistance becomes more difficult as the gap between the economic and military capabilities of the two countries continues to expand in favour of China. To meet this challenge, India’s strategy will need to be based on a deeper understanding of this rising power, including its history, its perceptions of India and the world, and its likely trajectory in the foreseeable future.

The ongoing Covid-19 pandemic will have its own impact on the geopolitical landscape in Asia and the world. Will it reinforce Chinese power or diminish it? Will there still be areas where India and China could find common ground, or are we condemned to a period of enduring hostility? Are there ways in which India may be able to constrain the unilateral assertion of power and influence by China, and are there potential partners to support such a countervailing strategy? I hope the pages that follow, which examine these questions and issues, will help identify markers from history that may serve as reference points in making well-considered projections and decisions on them.

I hope too that this book will bring the story of China to a more general readership in India and evoke in them a wider interest in China’s fascinating past as well as its contemporary development. My aim has been to provide